

successful investor is usually an individual who is inherently interested in business problems. This results in his discussing such matters in a way that will arouse the interest of those from whom he is seeking data. Naturally he must have reasonably good judgment or all the data he gets will avail him nothing.

An investor may have the time, inclination, and judgment but still be blocked from getting maximum results in the handling of his common stocks. The matter of geography is also a factor. An investor, for example, living in or near Detroit would have opportunities for learning about automotive accessory and parts companies that would not be available to one equally diligent or able in Oregon. But so many major companies and industries are today organized on a nation-wide basis with distribution, if not manufacturing, centers in most key cities, that investors living in larger industrial centers or their suburbs usually have ample opportunities to practice the art of finding at least a few outstanding long-range investments. This unfortunately is not equally true for those living in rural areas remote from such centers.

However, the rural investor or the overwhelming majority of other investors who may not have the time, inclination, or ability to uncover outstanding investments for themselves are by no means barred from making such investments because of this. Actually, the investor's work is so specialized and so intricate that there is no more reason why an individual should handle his own investments than that he should be his own lawyer, doctor, architect, or automobile mechanic. He should perform these functions if he has special interest in and skill at the particular field. Otherwise, he definitely should go to an expert.

What is important is that he know enough of the principles involved so that he can pick a real expert rather than a hack or a charlatan. In some ways it is easier for a careful layman to pick an outstanding investment advisor than, say, a comparably superior doctor or lawyer. In other ways it is much harder. It is harder because the investment field has developed much more recently than most comparable specialties. As a result mass ideas have not yet crystallized to the point where there is an accepted line of demarcation between true knowledge and mumbojumbo. There are not as yet the barriers to weed out the ignorant and the incompetent in the financial field that exist, for example, in the fields of law or medicine. Even among some of